WHITE PAPER

Deterministic English-Hebrew code-switching text-to-speech

How small, existing components chain into a pipeline that voices the Hebrew words in an English script as Hebrew, with one voice. A worked example from an AI-generated podcast.

AUTHOR
Daniel Rosehill

DATE
20/10/2026

Daniel Rosehill · Hebrish (hebrish.app) · 2026-10-20 · Repository: github.com/Hebrish-ASR/English-Hebrew-Code-Switching-TTS-Pipeline

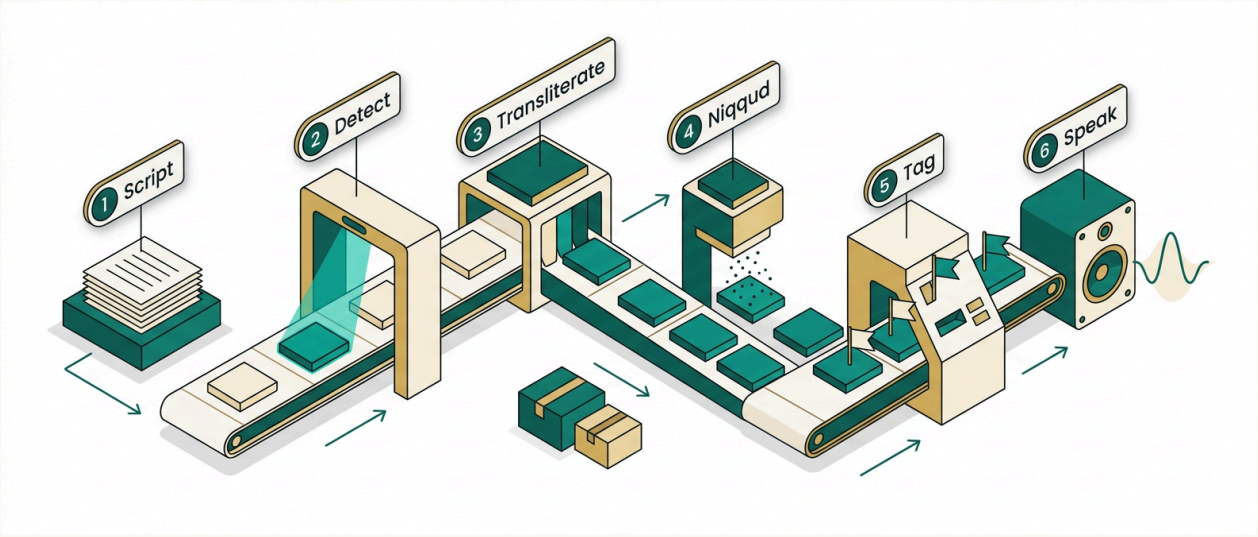


Figure 1: The pipeline as a production line. Illustration generated with an image model; the diagrams below carry the exact text.

Status. This is a documented pipeline, not a packaged service. Stages 2 to 5 run end to end on CPU in the repository; the outputs shown here are real. The TTS stage is written against the Chatterbox source and has not been run. Anyone is welcome to package the stages as a container, a Replicate model or a Space, and share it.

1. The problem

My Weird Prompts is an AI-generated podcast produced in Jerusalem. An LLM writes each script in English, and Chatterbox TTS voices it. When an episode is about life in Israel, Hebrew terms arrive in Latin letters: *I need to go to Bituach Leumi before the makolet closes.* The script is itself code-

switched. An English voice reads *makolet* as “MACK-oh-let”. Words English already knows (*Shabbat*, *kosher*) come out fine; the long tail of everyday Israeli life does not.

2. Why standard tools miss it

The characters give nothing away. Hebrew letters have their own Unicode block (U+0590 to U+05FF), so Hebrew *script* inside English is trivial to find. Romanized Hebrew is made of the same Basic Latin characters as the English around it; nothing at the character level marks a switch.

Language identification has no answer. GlotLID, fastText `lid.176` and `lid218e` have no label for Hebrew in Latin script (`heb_Latn`). Sentence-level language ID would call a 90%-English sentence English anyway. A TTS pipeline needs the character offsets of each Hebrew word: token classification.

Translating is not a fix. Many terms have no good English equivalent, and the translation is not what a listener in Israel would say.

3. The pipeline



Figure 2: One sentence through the six stages. Hebrew forms are the real stage 4 output.

#	Stage	Component	Licence	Status
1	Script	Any LLM writing English with romanized Hebrew		Input
2	**Detect**	`Hebrish/Hebrew-Latin-Token-Classifier` (xlm-roberta-base; labels O, B-HE, I-HE)	MIT	Built by Hebrish; run
3	**Transliterate**	Curated lexicon, then `malper/taatiknet` (ByT5) per word	TaatikNet weights: none stated; data CC-BY-SA 3.0	Existing; run
4	**Niqqud**	`dicta-il/dictabert-large-char-menaked`, for unpointed lexicon forms	CC-BY-4.0	Existing; run
5	**Tag**	Plain code: one (text, language) segment per piece		Run
6	**Speak**	Chatterbox Multilingual, `language_id` per call; or an Azure multilingual voice with SSML `<lang xml:lang="he-IL">`	MIT (Chatterbox)	Written, not run

Stage 2: detect

The only Hebrish model in the chain. Span F1 0.941 on a term-disjoint test set (no Hebrew term in the test set appears in training), and no false positives on 58 hard negatives. The labelling test is pronunciation, not etymology: *Shabbat*, *kosher* and *hummus* are not flagged. Use the repository's `predict.py`: the stock transformers pipeline labels sub-tokens and produced stray one-letter spans in our run.

Stage 3: transliterate

A curated lexicon of expected terms is primary. TaatikNet, the one open model for romanized Hebrew to Hebrew script, is the fallback. It is word-level (trained on about 15K single Wiktionary words), has no sentence context, and returns Hebrew already pointed.

Stage 4: niqqud

DICTA's nakdan adds vowel points to the unpointed lexicon forms, so the voice does not have to guess how to say them: מַבּוֹלֶת → מבולת. Its default output is the standard pointed spelling without vowel letters. It needs `transformers<5`: under 5.x its character tokenizer loads as word-level and the output comes back unpointed, with no error. Phonikud is the alternative when the TTS engine takes phonemes rather than text.

Stage 5: tag

Split the sentence at every switch:

`en` 'I need to go to ' · `he` בְּטוּחַ לְאֻמִּי · `en` ' before the ' · `he` מַבּוֹלֶת · `en` ' closes.'

Stage 6: speak

Chatterbox Multilingual supports Hebrew (`"he"`) but takes the language per call, not inline, so each segment is voiced separately with the same voice prompt and the clips are joined with short padding. Two cautions from its source: for Hebrew its tokenizer tries to re-diacritize with `dicta_onnx`, replacing your niqqud, so leave that package uninstalled; and voicing Hebrew with an English reference clip bleeds accent, which `cfg_weight=0` reduces. Among hosted engines, only Azure's multilingual voices accept inline `<lang xml:lang="he-IL">`; Google documents Hebrew in `<lang>` as unsupported and Polly has no Hebrew.

4. Worked examples (real output)

Sentence	Span	Score	Stage 3	Stages 3-4 output
I need to go to Bituach Leumi before the makolet closes.	`Bituach Leumi`	0.998	lexicon	בִּטּוּחַ לְאֻמִּי
	`makolet`	0.999	lexicon	מַבּוֹלֶת
My savta says the arnona went up again, so I called the iriya.	`savta`	1.0	taatiknet	סַוְטָה ✗ (correct: סָבְתָּא)
	`arnona`	0.996	lexicon	אַרְנוֹנָה
	`iriya`	0.998	taatiknet	אִירְיָה ✗ (correct: עִירְיָה)
We spent Shabbat with the mishpacha and the kids ate bamba all afternoon.	`mishpacha`	0.998	taatiknet	מִשְׁפָּחָה
	`bamba`	0.993	taatiknet	בַּמְבָּה

Both errors come from TaatikNet guessing a spelling without context, which is why the lexicon is primary: adding *savta* and *iriya* to it fixes them. *Shabbat* was correctly left as English.

5. Deterministic, or a model that switches by itself

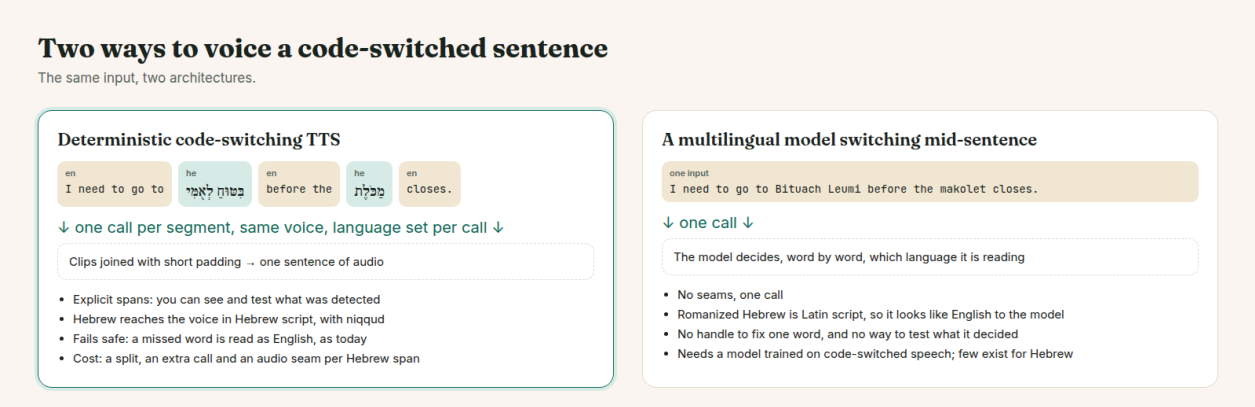


Figure 3: The same sentence, two architectures.

The deterministic pipeline decides every switch in code before the TTS sees the text: what was detected can be read, tested and corrected one word at a time, and a missed word fails safe to today's behaviour. Its cost is a split, an extra TTS call and an audio seam per Hebrew span, so the detector favours precision. The alternative, one multilingual model trusted to switch mid-sentence, gets no script signal from romanized Hebrew and offers no handle on its decisions. A TTS model trained on code-switched English-Hebrew speech could change that; we have not found an open one (searched 2026-10-20, not exhaustively).

6. The contract between stages

Each stage reads and extends one JSON object, so any stage can be swapped for another implementation:

```
{
 "text": "I need to go to Bituach Leumi before the makolet closes.",
 "spans": [{"start": 16, "end": 29, "surface": "Bituach Leumi", "score": 0.998, "hebrew": "ביטוח לאומי", "source": "lexicon",
"pointed": "בִּטּוּחַ לְאֻמִּי"}, …],
 "segments": [{"text": "I need to go to ", "lang": "en"},
   {"text": "בִּטּוּחַ לְאֻמִּי", "lang": "he"},
   {"text": " before the ", "lang": "en"},
   {"text": "מַכֹּלֶת", "lang": "he"},
   {"text": " closes.", "lang": "en"}]
}
```

7. What is open

- Run stage 6 end to end and listen: how Chatterbox's Hebrew voice reads pointed text with an English reference voice, and how much padding the joins need.
- Package the stages as one service. Anyone is welcome to; tell us and we will link it.
- Replace the demo lexicon with a curated term list.
- The approach carries over to any community that mixes its own words into a majority language in Latin script; only the term list and the stage 3-4 models are Hebrew-specific.

References

Detector: huggingface.co/Hebrish/Hebrew-Latin-Token-Classifier (original DOI 10.57967/hf/10997) · TaatikNet: huggingface.co/malper/taatiknet, github.com/morrisalp/taatiknet · DICTA nakdan: huggingface.co/dicta-il/dictabert-large-char-menaked · Phonikud: github.com/thewh1teagle/phonikud · Chatterbox: github.com/resemble-ai/chatterbox · Azure SSML: learn.microsoft.com/azure/ai-services/speech-service/speech-synthesis-markup-voice · Google SSML: docs.cloud.google.com/text-to-speech/docs/ssml · Polly languages: docs.aws.amazon.com/polly/latest/dg/supported-languages.html. Code MIT; text and figures CC-BY-4.0.